

Saying times and making appointments

Teaching guide

Agree on an unambiguous time.

Understand the distinction

You can say 9:15 as nine fifteen or a quarter past nine. 9:45 can be nine forty-five or a quarter to ten. Digital forms are often easiest when confirming an appointment.

Use a.m. or p.m. when the part of the day is unclear. Noon is midday; midnight is the start of a new day in date-based schedules. Include the date and time zone for an international meeting. Confirm rather than guess.

Compare the patterns

PAST THE HOUR

a quarter past nine

9:15

BEFORE THE HOUR

a quarter to ten

9:45

CONFIRM

Is that 9 a.m. Tokyo time?

Clarify the time zone and part of day.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Write half past two in numbers.

2. Write a quarter to six in numbers.

3. What should you clarify in Let's meet at eight if you are in different countries?

Use it in your own life

Write an appointment and a question confirming its time zone.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. 2:30

Half past means thirty minutes after the hour.

2. 5:45

It is fifteen minutes before six.

3. The date, a.m. or p.m., and time zone.

A complete appointment avoids assumptions.

One possible response

Let's meet on 12 September at 10 a.m. Is that London time?

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-31.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write an appointment and a question confirming its time zone.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.